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ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

31st WEEK



THAM LUANG CAVE RESCUE ... ATTITUDE

UPSC CSE – GS IV

GS IV ... Ethics, Integrity and Aptitude



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

3rd AUGUST, 2018

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Lessons from Tham Luang

A crisis can either unite people or expose faultlines. Rescue of stranded children in Thailand can teach India



JANMEJAYA SINHA

THE RESCUE of the Wild Boar football team and their coach from the Tham Luang caves in Thailand was spectacular, not in my mind just because of its difficulty or the skill and courage of the divers, but for a set of reasons that have not found much echo in the media. Let me highlight what I found awe-inspiring.

A youth football team of 12 boys, between the ages of 11 and 16, and a 25-year-old coach, got trapped. A search operation is launched and it becomes clear that the boys are lost inside the treacherous Tham Luang caves. Premature heavy rains have flooded the caves and made them inaccessible. To rescue the boys, the authorities start pumping water out of the caves and invite the Thai navy units to launch a rescue mission. The team reaches the conclusion that international help is needed for the search operation as they do not have the requisite cave-diving expertise. A British cartographer of the Tham Luang cave, resident in Thailand, suggests two expert cave divers from Britain be called in. With their help, an international rescue team is set up and works in complete coordination with a single chain of command. They work out a daring rescue strategy which we all know was successful and saved the entire team against heavy odds. This part has been widely applauded.

What has scarcely been highlighted is the role of different groups during the entire rescue — the parents, the media, political parties, the international rescue team and the chain of command (the navy units and doctors who stayed inside with the team) and the conduct of the football team and the coach inside the cave. This was a human interest story and captivated the whole world. Yet, the behaviour of the different groups in Thailand was exemplary in avoiding any sensationalism and partisanship.

Through the entire rescue, the parents stayed together. None of them blamed the coach nor went after his family. They supported each other and did not interfere in the rescue. They did not try to get their kids out first and where the children came out in batches stayed together until all the boys were rescued. They did not try and interview the kids before they were allowed to and gave no long press interviews during or after the rescue.

The media focused on the rescue mission, and did professional reporting based on the reports provided to them by the rescue team. They did not try to interview the parents separately, did not reach out to friends or teachers and did not second-guess the rescue effort. Even after the rescue, they did not sensationalise the event. They did not overplay Eton Musk's offer when it was refused by the rescue team. They reported with empathy and stayed

within bounds. When they were told that they can meet the children only once before they returned home and needed to get their questions asked by a psychiatrist, they complied. No one tried to get a breaking story. Contrast this with the role the media played during the terrorist attack in Mumbai. There was 24/7 reporting, every channel looking for the other, playing it straight into the hands of the terrorists. No one cared, channel ratings were paramount.

Political parties completely stayed out of the process. The local governor was in charge and people let him get on with the job. No red shirt, yellow shirt protests. No fault finding. No complaints on why the caves were not shut in the rainy season, no comments on how they were poorly maintained, or on the speed of action and the time taken to complete the rescue. The only time the prime minister spoke was when it was over. He did not seek any credit. The governor who organised the entire rescue effort is still hardly recognisable.

The rescue team had a clear chain of command, no contradictory messages, once a decision was taken it was executed. Media briefings were coordinated and even after the rescue there was hardly any big media outreach. The only time there was any back and forth was when adviser Eton Musk who had called him a paragon after the rescue team refused his submarine. In fact, the only two people who tried to capture the spotlight were President Donald Trump saying the Americans were leading the rescue, and Eton Musk who wanted to test his unsinkable submarine inside the cave.

The boys and their coach. The young kids, caught in a terrifying cave without food with a 25-year-old coach, stayed together. No bickering, no blame. The coach did not let what the boys could do over the limited food they had with them, helped them meditate to reduce the panic and fear. The boys themselves sent helpful messages to their parents apologising, not blaming anyone.

The absence of blame or politicking, parental unity, media restraint, football team cohesion, rescue team clarity, were all truly remarkable. As ex-novo seal died and his wife showed composure, a grief wrapped in pride. The first thing the team did after their release was to organise a prayer for the brave ex-novo seal in the hospital. The character of the nation on display was awe-inspiring.

What lessons are there in the rescue for us as a nation? To begin at a national scale either create the conditions for national unity or give voice to nation-destroying particular personal prejudices. Accumulated not, race conflicts, caste wars are all deeply divisive. Alternatively, a natural calamity like a tsunami or flooding of children inside a cave, or a terrorist attack on a city, offer an opportunity to strengthen the underlying national bonds. But this may not happen due to jealousy, sensationalism or self-interest. Watching the dignity of the Thai deal with the cave rescue have major lessons for us. But will we learn?

The writer is chairman, Asia Pacific, Boston Consulting Group. Views are personal

3 Lessons from Tham Luang

A crisis can either unite people or expose faultlines. Rescue of stranded children in Thailand can teach India. The rescue of the Wild Boar football team and their coach from the Tham Luang caves in Thailand was spectacular, not in my mind just because of its difficulty or the skill and courage of the divers, but for a set of reasons that have not found much echo in the media. Let me highlight what I found awe-inspiring.

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...Contd.



3 Lessons from Tham Luang

Through the entire rescue, the parents stayed together. None of them blamed the coach nor went after his family. They supported each other and did not interfere with the rescue. They did not try to get their kids out first and when the children came out in batches stayed together until all the boys were rescued. They did not try and meet the kids before they were allowed too and none gave long press interviews during or after the rescue.

The media focused on the rescue mission, and did professional reporting based on the reports provided to them by the rescue team. They did not try and interview the parents separately, did not reach out to friends or teachers and did not second-guess the rescue effort. Even after the rescue, they did not sensationalise the event. They did not overplay Elon Musk's offer when it was refused by the rescue team. They reported with empathy and stayed within bounds. When they were told that they can meet the children only once before they returned home and needed to get their questions vetted by a psychiatrist, they complied. No one tried to get a breaking story. Contrast this with the role the media played during the terrorist attack in Mumbai. There was 24/7 reporting, every channel outdoing the other, playing straight into the hands of the terrorists. No one cared, channel ratings were paramount.

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The boys and their coach: The young kids, caught in a terrifying cave without food with a 25-year-old coach, stayed together. No bickering, no blame. The coach did not eat so that the boys could share the limited food they had with them, helped them meditate to reduce the panic and fear. The boys themselves sent hopeful messages to their parents apologising, not blaming anyone.

The absence of blame or politicking, parental unity, media restraint, football team cohesion, rescue team clarity, were all truly remarkable. An ex-navy seal died and his wife showed composure, a grief wrapped in pride. The first thing the team did after their release was to organise a prayer for the brave ex-navy seal in the hospital. The character of the nation on display was awe-inspiring.

What lessons are there in the rescue for us as a nation? Tragedies at a national scale either create the conditions for national unity or give voice to nation-destroying partisan primordial tendencies. A communal riot, race conflicts, caste wars are all deeply divisive, alternatively, a natural calamity like a tsunami or flooding of children inside a cave, or a terrorist attack on a city, offer an opportunity to strengthen the underlying national bonds. But this may not happen due to apathy, sensationalism or self-interest. Watching the dignity of the Thais deal with the cave rescue have major lessons for us. But will we learn?



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The media focused on the rescue mission, and did professional reporting based on the reports provided to them by the rescue teams. They did not try and interview the parents separately, did not rush out to friends or teachers and did not second-guess the rescue effort even after the rescue. They did not sensationalise the event. They did not overplay Eton Musk's offer when it was refused by the rescue teams. They reported with empathy and stayed

within bounds. When they were told that they can meet the children only once before they returned home and send out their questions vetted by a psychiatrist, they complied. No one tried to get a breaking story. Content fit with the role the media played during the terrorist attack in Mumbai. There was 24/7 reporting, every channel/broadcasting the other playing straight into the hands of the terrorists. No one cared, channel ratings were paramount.

Political parties completely stayed out of the process. The local governor was in charge and people let him get on with the job. He led short, yellow shirt protests, no fault finding. No complaints on why the cave were not shut in the rainy season, no comments on how they were poorly maintained, or on the speed of action and the time taken to complete the rescue. The only time the prime minister spoke was when it was over. He did not seek any credit. The governor who organised the entire rescue effort is still hardly recognisable.

The rescue team had a clear chain of command, no contradictory messages, once a decision was taken it was executed. Media briefings were coordinated and even after the rescue there was hardly any big media outreach. The only time there was any back and forth was when a diver fell into against Eton Musk who had called him a parakeet after the rescue team refused his submarine. In fact, the only two people who tried to capture the spotlight were President Donald Trump, saying the Americans were leading the rescue, and Eton Musk who wanted to test his unbreakable submarine inside the cave.

The boys and their coach: The young kids, caught in a terrifying cave without food with a 25-year-old coach, stayed together. No bickering, no blame. The coach did not act that the boys could share the limited food they had with them, helped them meditate to endure the pain and fear. The boys themselves sent hopeful messages to their parents apologising, not blaming anyone.

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What lessons are there in the rescue for us as a nation? Tragedies at a national scale either create the conditions for national unity or give voice to nation-destroying partisan personalities/tendencies. Accidents, not, race conflicts, caste wars are all deeply divisive, alternatively, a natural calamity like a tsunami or flooding of children inside a cave, or a terrorist attack on a city offer an opportunity to strengthen the underlying national bonds. But this may not happen due to apathy, sensationalism or self-interest. Watching the dignity of the Thai deal with the cave rescue have major lessons for us. But will we learn?

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The Indian EXPRESS
JOURNALISM OF COURAGE

3rd August, 2018

UPSC CSE – GS IV

GS IV ... Ethics, Integrity and Aptitude

Attitude: content, structure, function; its influence and relation with thought and behaviour; moral and political attitudes; social influence and persuasion.

IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY / MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

Decent behaviour, avoiding sensationalism, focusing on core task were the hallmarks of Tham Luang cave rescue in Thailand. Examine how this attitude is entirely different from the one experienced in Countries like India, under such circumstances.



NEWS REPORT



- 1 The rescue of the Wild Boars football team and their coach from the Tham Luang cave in Thailand was spectacular
- 2 Young football team of 12 boys, between the ages of 11 and 16, and a 25-year-old coach went missing.
- 3 Premature heavy rains flooded the caves and made them inaccessible.
- 4 A British cartographer of the Tham Luang cave, resident in Thailand, suggests two expert cave divers from Britain be called in.
- 5 With their help, an international rescue team was set up and worked in complete coordination with a single chain of command.



WHAT WAS FORGOTTEN IN THE MEDIA REPORTS!

- 1 Parents stayed together, none of them blamed the coach nor went after his family. They supported each other and did not interfere with the rescue.
- 2 They did not try to get their kids out first and when the children came out in batches, they stayed together until all the boys were rescued. Media focused on the rescue mission, and did professional reporting based on the reports provided to them by the rescue team.
- 3 They did not try and interview the parents separately, nor did reach out to the friends or teachers.



WHAT WAS FORGOTTEN IN THE MEDIA REPORTS!

- 4 They did not sensationalise the event.
- 5 When the media was told that their questions are to be vetted by a psychiatrist, they complied.
- 6 No one tried to get a breaking story and this is in sharp contrast to the 24X7 report during terrorist attack in Mumbai.
- 7 Political parties completely stayed out of the process. The local Governor was in charge.
- 8 No fault finding, no complaints on why the caves were not shut in the rainy season.
- 9 The Governor, who organised the entire rescue effort is still barely recognisable.

**Donald Trump****Elon Musk**

WHAT ABOUT THE RESCUE TEAM?

- 1** The rescue team had a clear chain of command, no contradictory messages,
- 2** Media briefings were coordinated and even after the rescue, there was hardly any big media outreach.
- 3** Only two people who tried to steal the limelight were President Donald Trump and Elon Musk, when Trump said Americans were leading the rescue and Elon Musk wanted to test his unworkable submarine inside the cave.



WHAT ABOUT BOYS AND THEIR COACH?

- 1** Boys and 25 year old coach stayed together, no blame game.
- 2** The coach did not eat, so that the boys could share the limited food they had with them.
- 3** The coach helped them meditate to reduce the panic and fear.
- 4** The boys themselves sent hopeful messages to their parents apologising, not blaming anyone.



WHAT IS THE FINAL CONCLUSION?

- Absence of blame or politicking
- Parental unity
- Media restraint
- Football team cohesion
- Rescue team clarity

An ex-navy Seal died and his wife showed composure, a grief wrapped in pride. The character of the Nation on display was awe-inspiring.



Watching the dignity of the Thai's deal with the cave rescue have major lessons for us.

WHAT LESSONS ARE TO BE LEARNT?

- 1** Tragedies of the national scale either create the conditions for national unity or give voice to nation-destroying partisan tendencies.
- 2** A communal riot, race conflicts, caste wars are deeply divisive.
- 3** Alternatively, a natural calamity like a tsunami or flooding of children inside a cave, or a terrorist attack on a city, offer an opportunity to strengthen the underlying national bonds.

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SINCERE THANKS
FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

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